

New Orleans–Style Red Beans and Rice

PREP: 20 MINS | STOVE: 2.5 - 3 HRS | SLOW COOKER: 7 - 8 HRS

"A true Louisiana staple. This recipe yields perfectly creamy, deeply savory red beans simmered low and slow with the holy trinity of vegetables, a smoky ham hock, and deeply browned Andouille sausage."

INGREDIENTS

THE AROMATICS & MEAT

- **1 lb** dried red kidney beans
(rinsed and picked over)
- **2 tbsp** vegetable oil or lard
- **1 lb** Andouille sausage
(sliced into ¼-inch rounds)
- **1 large** yellow onion (finely diced)
- **1 green bell pepper** (finely diced)
- **3 ribs** celery (finely diced)
- **4 cloves** garlic (minced)
- **1 smoked ham hock**
(or meaty ham bone)

THE SIMMER & SEASONING

- **6 cups** chicken stock (Stovetop)
OR 4½ to 5 cups (Slow Cooker)
- **2** dried bay leaves
- **1 tsp** dried thyme
- **1 tsp** Cajun or Creole seasoning
- **½ tsp** cayenne pepper (adjust for heat)
- **1 tsp** hot sauce (such as Crystal or Tabasco)
- Kosher salt and black pepper (to taste)

FOR SERVING

- Cooked long-grain white rice

STOVETOP INSTRUCTIONS

STEP 1: SOAK THE BEANS

Place the dried red beans in a large bowl and cover with water by at least 2 inches. Allow them to soak overnight (or for at least 8 hours). Drain and rinse the beans before starting to cook.

STEP 2: BROWN THE SAUSAGE

Heat the vegetable oil or lard in a large, heavy Dutch oven over medium-high heat. Add the sliced Andouille sausage and cook until it is beautifully browned and has released its flavorful fat (about 5–7 minutes). Use a slotted spoon to remove the sausage and set aside, leaving the rendered fat in the pot.

STEP 3: SAUTÉ THE HOLY TRINITY

Turn the heat down to medium. Add the diced onion, green bell pepper, and celery (the Louisiana Holy Trinity) directly into the hot sausage fat. Cook, stirring occasionally, for 8–10 minutes until the vegetables are completely soft and translucent. Stir in the minced garlic and cook for 1 additional minute until fragrant.

STEP 4: LOW AND SLOW SIMMER

Pour the soaked and drained beans into the pot. Add the 6 cups of chicken stock, smoked ham hock, bay leaves, dried thyme, Cajun seasoning, and cayenne pepper. Bring the entire mixture to a rolling boil, then lower the heat to medium-low. Cover tightly and let it simmer for 1½ to 2 hours, or until the beans are tender.

- Fresh scallions (thinly sliced)
- Extra hot sauce for the table

STEP 5: CREATE THE SIGNATURE CREAMINESS

Uncover the pot and return the browned Andouille sausage to the beans. To achieve the classic creamy texture, take a heavy wooden spoon and mash a portion of the beans against the side of the Dutch oven. Stir well and let simmer uncovered for another 30 minutes until the liquid thickens into a rich, luscious gravy. Stir in the hot sauce, and season with salt and pepper to taste.

STEP 6: PLATE AND SERVE

Remove and discard the bay leaves and the ham hock bone (shred any meat remaining on the hock back into the pot). Spoon a generous portion of the creamy red beans over a bed of warm white rice. Garnish heavily with sliced scallions and serve alongside extra hot sauce.

SLOW COOKER CONVERSION ALTERNATIVE

1. **Soak & Pre-Boil:** Soak beans overnight. *Crucial Safety Step:* To completely destroy toxins present in raw kidney beans, boil the soaked beans in fresh water for 10 minutes on the stove, then drain before adding them to the slow cooker.
2. **Sauté Base:** Brown the sausage and sauté the Holy Trinity with garlic in a skillet on the stove exactly as detailed in Stovetop Steps 2 & 3 to build deep color and flavor. Transfer everything into the slow cooker basin.
3. **Load Basin:** Add the pre-boiled beans, sautéed vegetables, ham hock, bay leaves, thyme, Cajun seasoning, and cayenne. Pour in **only 4½ to 5 cups** of chicken stock (less is needed as no liquid evaporates). Hold back the sausage and hot sauce until the end.
4. **Cook Time:** Cover and cook on **LOW for 7 to 8 hours** (preferred) or on HIGH for 4 to 5 hours.
5. **Finish:** 30 minutes before completing, stir in the reserved sausage rounds. Mash a portion of the beans against the crock wall to create the signature thick gravy. Discard bay leaves, shred ham hock meat back in, stir in the hot sauce, and serve over warm white rice!

TRADITION & TEXTURE TIPS

Mashing is Key: Authentic Creole and Cajun red beans get their velvety thickness not from flour or cornstarch, but from the natural starches released when you mash a cup or two of the soft beans right against the inner walls of the pot.

The Next Day Effect: Like many slow-cooked dishes, red beans taste significantly richer the next day once the smoky flavors from the pork, spices, and starch have fully melded together in the fridge.